

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

This month in Alt, we discuss if the upgrade to Windows 11 is worth it, we speak to Amazon about the electronics space in India, we take a look at some droolworthy tech, and of course, we've got memes!



Live bird migration

Check out this site that shows migrations of birds in real time, with millions of birds tracked using radar technology typically used for forecasting the weather. There are also bird migration alerts, and forecast maps for the most likely future migrations.

<https://dgit.in/birbmg>

WHAT'S NEW

Ransomware and political warfare

It is no longer just the cybercriminals who are looking for easy money, who use the approach of encrypting the files of attacked users, and demanding a cryptocurrency ransom for encrypting the data. Along with private military contractors, using state resources for surveillance, and disinformation machines, ransomware is another addition in the toolbox for political warfare. There has been a surge in ransomware attacks on what is considered critical state infrastructure, which is making politicians take the threat more seriously, elevating ransomware to a national security threat. A number of Russian operations have emerged that provide ransomware as a service, and for these outfits the



lines between state run outfits and cybercriminal organisations is pretty blurred. The attackers refrain from targeting

Russian organisations or businessmen, and in turn they are left to operate in impunity, as they are immune from legal consequences in Russia. The dark market forums in Russia easily allow the conversion of cryptocurrency into cash. Western researchers have termed this approach "strategic inaction" by the Russian government, that enables experimenting with malicious software aimed at western targets. <https://dgit.in/rusran>

Why do we sleep?

Over the past few decades, extensive research into how animals sleep has resulted in large quantities of data. However, despite all of the recorded data, scientists lack a theory that can predict for example why mice sleep 10 times longer than whales, why infant humans sleep longer than adult humans, or why REM and sleep time changes rapidly as a baby grows. There is still a glaring lack of a general quantitative theory



on explaining why we sleep. Now, researchers are tackling the question head on, with a focus on the biological utility of sleep, rather than merely cataloguing the various aspects

and properties of sleep. The new approach uses mathematical models, and combines all the data previously collected in sleep research. These researchers have uncovered a sudden shift in the function of sleep between infants and adults, which is similar to a shift from water to ice. In children, sleep is for neural reorganisation, but in adults, the function of sleep for maintenance and repair of the brain.

<https://dgit.in/whysleep>



Inventing your death

Check out this list of thirteen inventors, who through a series of unfortunate events ended up being killed by their own inventions, including a runaway lighthouse, an out of control barrel, a treacherous pulley system, a propellor driven train, and of course a flying car that didn't.

<https://dgit.in/rekt>



Chasing immortality

A number of silicon valley billionaires are throwing money at an age old quest, finding a way of making humans live forever. Advances in biotechnology has led to a number of companies attempting to slow down and even reverse the molecular mechanisms of ageing.

<https://dgit.in/svim>



The future of AI

This interview with Eric Schmidt charts the future of AI, evaluates exactly how disruptive the AI revolution is going to be, explores the possibility of the proliferation of AI driven misinformation, as well as the relationship between humans and machines over the next two decades.

<https://dgit.in/mai>